MOUNTAIN BOY

TALES FOR EVERYONE

URSULA WEST

CHAPTER 1

On a high mountain, far up in the hills of a far distant land, a young boy lived all alone.

"Go and find your own kind, his parents had told him, but now they were dead and gone and still he had not left the mountain.He was not very young, but he was not yet a man. That was why, on a beautiful day, he was sitting outside in his garden wondering what he should do.

The sun warmed his face as he gazed at the old stone well. How long had it been there? He did not know. The metal bucket hung silently from the pulley above the creamy stone wall of the well and walked over and sat on the edge, pushing the bucket a little to make it swing gently back and forth. He looked around. Wild flowers made pools of colour against the green trees further on. A bird darted quickly from one branch to another, then a rabbit popped out of its burrow and looked at him before quickly dashing away.

"Where are my own kind?" he thought. "Who are they?"

For a long while, he thought about this, quietly weighing up what he should do. But at last he decided. "I am all alone here," he said. "Perhaps it is better that I go."

So off he went on a journey of discovery, leaving behind his beautiful garden and well-kept house.

"Look after the fields," he called back to the wind and the rain. "I may be back."

He walked and walked for many days. At last, he came to a town, a strange town indeed, for there, in every garden, were rows of paper flowers.

The people in this town looked miserable. The boy looked around. He had never seen such dull and unhappy looking faces. He put out his hand as a drop of rain came down and he smiled as it touched his skin.

But not so the townspeople. There was a scurrying, a rushing, a flurrying and a dashing. People left their houses and ran to their gardens. They snatched, picked and grabbed at the paper flowers.

"The rain!" they shouted, "the rain!"

Into their houses they dashed with the flowers and banged their doors tight shut. Then their windows, cat flaps, letter boxes and anything else that might be open,

They left the boy standing alone in the rain.

Then, from their windows, the people watched. How amazed they all looked!

When the rain was over, they crept out again, one by one

They touched him, prodded him, stared so hard at him he even touched himself to see what was wrong.

"What's wrong?" he said,

"Why, he is still alive!" they exclaimed.

"Off course I am," he said, "why shouldn't I be?"

"But we thought the rain would kill you. No one here has gone out in the rain for as long as we can remember."

"But then, how do you work in the fields? How do you go for walks? How do you go for a swim?"

"We don't," they said simply. "We stay very close to home and we never go near the river. Everything we need is made indoors, even our flowers. We eat wild roots and mushrooms: it's a very boring life."

"It must be, said the boy. He thought for a minute, then took a bag of seeds from his pocket."

"I was going to plant these on my new farm," he said, "but you can have them. You see now that the rain is good. The rain is your friend and it will work with you to make these seeds grow."

"How foolish we have been," said the people. "No one would have been the first to get caught in the rain. We don't remember how we came to be frightened by it, but now we can see that it is only paper that melts in the rain."

As they talked, the rain started again and soaked them all where they stood. One by one, their grey faces turned upwards to let it run down their cheeks and over their arms. They rubbed it into their skin and through their hair, "THE RAIN! THE RAIN!" they shouted, and they danced around in it.

The boy waved goodbye — he could see they had a lot to do. "Maybe when I come back this way, I will call on you," "Yes, yes," they said. "Our town will never be the same again."

THE BOY WALKED on for three more days.

The second town was not like the first,
The second town could not be seen.
He could see the fields.
He could see the roads.

He could see people afar off - but he couldn't see the town.

Then he saw it, or should I say, he saw a door leading to it; a door in the ground.

He opened the door and called down. Is there anybody home?"

"Close the door!" someone shouted back. He closed it.

In a minute or two, it opened ever so slightly. A stick with a handkerchief tied to it, poked out of the door. The handkerchief did not move. "Ah! all right," said a voice.

"What was that for?" said the boy as the door opened completely and a man and a woman stepped up and out to stand beside him.

"That was to see if there was any wind." they said.

The man and the woman were covered with so many spots that the boy took one step backwards. Their hair was twisted and sculptured into stiff shapes and the pair could hardly move an inch without checking to see if it was still in place. "The wind might blow our hair out of place," they said.

Yes, this town was afraid of the wind. Once again, the boy had to point out what they were missing. He showed them how good the wind could be, how many more patterns the wind could make with leaves and rocks that were far more exciting than their sculptured hair. He persuaded them to get rid of the glue, to wash their hair till it was soft and silky and could blow about in the wind.

It was so long since they had felt such a wonderful feeling that joy completely overtook them. They stood while the wind blew wildly through their hair and they tossed handfuls of leaves to see how they landed. They noticed how many times the wind could change the landscape in one day; the moving branches of the trees, the flattened grass, and the rippling water.

"What a lot we have missed," they said. "We will have to build something up here so that we can stay and watch it.

"Good," said the boy "then in time, if I return this way, I might see that your whole town has come up from underground. And the boy walked on.

At the third town it was a similar story, He had to teach the people not to be afraid of the sunlight, for they all hid behind dreary curtains and wore extremely dark glasses. Bit by bit, they had forgotten about colour. They lived in a dark, grey world until the boy showed them what a flower looked like.

He went inside and lifted one tiny corner of a curtain and let in one tiny ray of light to fall on one tiny orange flower.

"Ah!" they all gasped, "how could we have been so foolish!

Although they could not take their glasses off too quickly for fear of being blinded or open up their heavy curtains, they went out at once to see if they could peek at some other flowers.

When the boy left them, they were all crawling about the ground peering closely at the tiny coloured flowers, lifting their glasses for a split second and gasping in wonder at what they saw.

"Goodbye," he said, "I'm sure I will find a brighter town if I come back this way."

"Yes, yes," they all said, "come back anytime."

And so, he walked on to the fourth and last town he was to visit. Surely no one was frightened here; no, they weren't, in fact they were lying about in the hot sun doing nothing. The town was the hottest place he had ever visited.

An empty drink can rolled around in the warm, sticky wind. A cobweb on a verandah caught the breeze and shook

a little. The people were the laziest looking bunch that the boy had ever seen.

"Does anyone do any work here?" he thought. The only movement he could see was someone yawning as he lay on the dusty ground under a tree. A hammock in a backyard swung a little, and a woman crossed the road. She walked as slow as a snail and indeed there was no need for her to hurry, for there was no sign of traffic anywhere.

The houses were falling down from need of repair and the fields were overgrown and messy.

"Well, I never!" said the boy to himself. "The quicker I get out of this town the better."

It was so hot and he had walked for so long that he needed a cool drink and a refreshing cold shower before he carried on. He went up to the man under the tree and asked him where he could find these two things.

The man suddenly laughed loudly.

"Not in this town, boy! Nope, that's impossible," he said and laughed again.

The boy was very puzzled. "But why ever not?"

The man turned round and propped himself up on one elbow. "Cause when it's hot, it's hot and all the water's hot and when it's cold, it's nighttime and we all be asleep at night. We get so tired out by the heat of the day, it's all we can do to get into our beds and have a good night's sleep."

"And is the water cold at night?" asked the boy.

"Yep, it's freezing, but who wants it then? It's so freezing everywhere, who wants to get colder?"

The man sighed from all this effort and turned on his back again and continued speaking with his eyes closed.

"As soon as the sun comes up in the morning, the water heats back up again and so do we, so we just wait for the night to cool off."

"When do you work?" asked the boy.

"Never," said the man, "it's too hot."

A few people had noticed the noise going on in the square and had made the great effort to come and see who was talking. The fat man beneath the tree reckoned he had done enough work and was preparing to go back to sleep. Meanwhile, the crowd gathered round and looked closely at this small stranger. "Perfect," thought the boy. " I know exactly what they need." He squared himself and turned around to address them directly.

"Hello people. Here is an idea. Why don't. you keep some of the water from the night and use it to refresh yourselves during the day. Then you might feel like working and clean up your town.

"Impossible," they all said. "It heats up so quickly. It never stays cold."

"If I show you a way to do it, will you stay up tonight and help me?"

The fat man beneath the tree opened one eye and squinted at the boy. "You'd better be right son, he said "or you won't last through the next day."

"I'm right," said the boy softly. "Will you do it?"

Everyone in the crowd was silent. They looked at the boy and then at the fat man under the tree who had closed both eyes again. "All right," said the fat man. "I'll do it."

"Us too," they all said.

"And you had better be a jolly good runner if you're wrong boy," added the fat man and went back to sleep.

That night the boy told the people to dig a big square hole. He then told them to bring a big square tank and put it into the hole. When all that was done, he then told them to fill it to the very top with water.

By the time the tank was ready to be filled it was well into the night and the water had become icy cold. Unfortunately, so were the people and their nerves were getting very frayed.

They were hopping about from foot to foot and rubbing their hands together.

"What now?" they moaned. "We should be at home tucked up in our warm beds."

"Bring as many blankets as you can spare," said the boy.

They stopped rubbing their hands and stared in disbelief. Have they been following a fool? What were they to think of such a request?

"Blankets are to keep you hot lad, not to keep things cold!" said one man as he threw his shovel to the ground.

"Aye!" they all chanted. "What's all this nonsense about?"

They left their positions around the tank and moved in on the boy till the throng of angry townsfolk surrounded him.

"Give the boy a chance," said the fat man as he pushed past them. He looked at the boy's calm gaze. "You haven't heard his answer yet."

The boy smiled with a little relief. "Just do as I say," he said. "The blankets that stop the heat from getting out of you at night will also stop the heat from getting into the water during the day."

"You hope," said the fat man. "Come on, he called to the crowd "let's get the blankets."

The boy took the blankets and smothered the tank in them, some down the side of the hole but most of them on top.

"The sun comes up in one hour," said a woman as she gathered up her belongings. "We will see then if the boy has wasted our time or not."

"No," said the boy, "have your sleep and get up when the sun is at its hottest, in the middle of the day."

Nobody argued against a little more time to sleep and they agreed to meet at the tank at noon.

While the town slept, the sun came up and baked the earth again and blazed down till even the birds were too hot to fly and the spiders hid in the shade for fear of getting cooked on their webs. The dusty town was filled with the noise of snoring and none louder than that of the fat man under the big tree.

At noon there was a clanging and ringing of alarm clocks. The whole town stretched and yawned with one enormous yawn. One by one the people shuffled out to the square and stood around the boy who was already standing there with a jug in one hand.

"I will now open the small hatch and dip my jug into the water below. Who will be the first to try?" he called out.

"I will," said the fat man, and the crowd parted for him as he came forward.

"All right," said the boy and handed him a cup.

The boy opened the hatch and took out a jugful of water, drizzling it, slowly into the fat man's cup.

The man stared first at the water and then at the boy. As he put the cup to his lips, he glared non stop right into the boy's eyes.

He took his first sip and then another, still looking at the boy and then down at the cup.

"It's freezing," he whispered and then he shouted "IT'S FREEZING!"

With a great whoop, he threw the whole cup of water over his face. "It's freezing cold water! He shouted, freezing cold!"

In no time, everyone was flinging the water up in the air. Jugfuls were being splashed and showered about. Someone actually RAN into their house and brought out a bottle of fruit squash.

"Cold squash for sale!" they called, and the town's first cafe was in business.

The boy just looked on and laughed. The big fat man picked him up and danced around with him.

"You can be our first Mayor!" he shouted wildly.

"No," said the boy, "not me, I must go now, but you would make a good leader if you worked at it."

"Me?" said the fat man bashfully. "Why I'm just, well I'm just a…"

"Just what?" said the boy.

"Just nothing, I suppose. But now things have to change. I might just try to do something about this place. With the help of all the town we could have cold tanks in every house in two weeks' time. Then I'll make this place the best tourist spot in the entire country. Lots of sun and lots of nice cool water,

He put the boy down from his shoulders and looked at him with a gentle smile.

"But you, can't you stay with us?"

"No, not me. Now I know where I belong and I must return there." He told them about his lonely mountainside and his quiet life looking after his crops. The fat man promised he would come and visit him and the boy waved goodbye and set off for home.

When he arrived home, the house still stood where he had left it. The crops were still in the field, but now they were ripe and ready for the harvest. The well in his garden still sat silently amidst his flowers, and the stone seat outside his door was just as inviting to a tired traveller.

He sat down and looked around. "This is where I belong," he said, "even though I have no friends and I am all alone. I am happiest here."

A gentle breeze brushed his cheek, and a faint voice whis-

pered in his ear. It was the voice of the wind who had heard what he had said.

"You are not alone," it replied, "I am here with you. I scattered the seeds from your flowers and carried the pollen from the trees and in autumn I will blow their leaves and lay them at your door. I will always be with you. The boy nodded.

Then he heard a soft, pattering voice, and the rain whispered its reply. "No, no, no, you will never be alone. It was I who filled the well while you were gone and washed the stone that you are sitting on. I watered your flowers and your fields. I know I can be moody, but I try to be your friend; no, you are not alone, I will always be with you.

The boy laughed and said, "Yes, I know."

And then a clear tinkling voice sounded in his ear. It was the voice of the Ice. "Now then, how can you say you are alone? Do I not lie on your ground in winter and tear the soil with my icy grip? The heaviest solid earth will break and soften under my strong fingers. How would you have such good soil if it wasn't for my help? And while you hide from me inside your house, as well you should, outside I bring you snow to play with, to crunch and walk upon.

I paint the whole world in winter and lay the deepest, whitest carpet you have ever seen. So, what is this I am hearing? Come now my dear little friend, you are not alone, I will always be with you. The boy nodded and buried his head in his hands in joy.

"Yes," said a warm and gentle voice. It was the voice of the sun. The boy looked up and a ray of sunlight shone around him. From oh so far away, the glorious sun had reached down to where he sat and, with gentle fingers, stroked his cheek,

"You are not alone. I make you smile when you are low and dry your clothes and tell your time and wake the cock-

erel in the morning who sings so loudly that you could never sleep and miss the day. You skip and dance when I'm around — I know you like my company."

"Yes, I do," said the boy,

"Then you will never be alone," said the sun. "I will always be with you."

The boy stood up and waved his arms in the air.

"Thank you sun, thank you wind, thank you rain, thank you ice, you are all my friends. All these years, you have worked with me and I have never thanked you."

The wind blew.

The rain sent a sparkling shower.

The ice sent a momentary chill.

And the sun spread its arms wider with a splendid burst of light that crowned the mountainside.

The boy clapped and applauded and settled back down to work. In no time, his home looked as though he had never left it and he had gathered all his crops of winter.

Down in the four towns, the first, because of their very wet weather, opened the biggest water sports centre ever. They grew lots of delicious food in their well-watered fields, which they worked in, soaked to the skin and smiling.

The second town opened a hang-glider school and were so proud of their windswept town that they made houses with observation platforms to watch all the changes the wind could make. Day in and day out, a special flag stood, blowing in the wind to commemorate the boy's visit. Some clever clogs even invented a windmill, and that really got things moving…

The third town soon got rid of their dark glasses altogether. They threw back their heavy curtains and if the sun

faded their wallpaper, they would simply paint the wall. They became so fascinated by colour that they grew to be great artists and opened an art school which attracted people from all over the world.

And then the fourth town, well, in no time at all, their enthusiasm transformed the place. There was singing, dancing, chatting and lots and lots of hard work. Eventually, it became the liveliest tourist resort you have ever seen. It was known worldwide for its hot climate and icy waters and people just loved to bake in its sun then cool off in a cold shower.

And the boy on the mountain? He stayed there and grew to be a very wise old man. The people from the four towns came now and then to ask his advice which he always gave with a smile.

The big fat man became his special friend, although, with all his work he was a little thinner, but just a little. When the tourists became too much for him, the happy fat mayor of the fourth town could be found sitting quietly, chatting and drinking beside the well on the mountain and loving every minute.

For all I know, that's what he’s doing right now.